

Episode 79: Once Upon a Time... (50) – JMSDF Yokosuka Base Destroyer Location Scouting Chronicles!

Right now I'm working on the new programmes *Marie & Gali* (マリー & ガリー) starting in April (or more precisely, broadcasting from March 31st).

The script is by Yamada-san, Umakoshi-san's character design with Masuda-san's art, character colours by me - the same crew from that pilot version. The direction team will be centered on the promising young directors Tsuchida-kun, Kureta-kun, and Komaki-san, who were active in *GeGeGe no Kitaro*. The voice actors are also the same crew from the pilot version.

A 5-minute programmes on NHK Educational TV, and a science anime at that? It's a somewhat unusual format, but with the feeling of "if we can make something weird, we win," we're progressing enjoyably and steadily. Please look forward to it!

Now then.

Following up on the location scouting I wrote about last time, here's the story of COO's second location scouting expedition. Six months after the "Aburatsubo location scouting" in early summer 1992, we went out on location scouting again.

"Huh? Location scouting? This time surely the South Pacific? (hopeful)"

"Mm, Yokosuka."

"...Ah, Yokosuka? (sweat)"

Actually, in the latter half of the story, a fleet of the French Navy (I think it was French?) appears in the production. If it were just the exterior appearance, we might have

managed somehow with photo references, but there were scenes of Yosuke and others being confined inside the ship, with various interior ship scenes appearing.

Not a passenger ship, but a warship.

We hadn't even been on many passenger ships, let alone warships. Unlike passenger ships designed for comfortable living, warships designed for combat with all waste eliminated would be completely different, you'd think.

So...

"Warships and such, you really need to see proper ones once, in person. It's hard to draw storyboards without really understanding them," said Director Imazawa. And animation director Okura, who loves mechanical warships. The director's storyboard work was almost finished, but he seemed stuck on this warship-related section along with the settings.

Nowadays, if you search the internet, there's an incredible amount of reference photos and footage overflowing on the web, but in 1992, such convenient things weren't available yet. But you can't just say "let's go see them" because they're military secrets, so naturally they wouldn't show them to us.

However, Kadokawa Shoten (角川書店) and Toei Animation applied for coverage to the Japan Maritime Self-Defence Force public relations department, and amazingly, we were able to cover active JMSDF vessels stationed at Yokosuka Base. Wow! That's what big companies can do. Individuals could never make this happen, I'm sure.

So we main staff gathered at Keikyu Taura Station on the Keihin Kyuko line. It was a certain day in December 1992. A day of harsh cold winds... no, it was actually a relatively warm, pleasant Indian summer day.

We walked from the station to the Japan Maritime Self-Defence Force Yokosuka District Funakoshi Base. After passing through the guardhouse, we waited in a small office-like place for the public relations people. Eventually about three people in uniform arrived. Led by them, we walked along the pier to where the vessels we could tour were moored.

While slightly nervous, we were all boys at heart, already gripping our cameras tightly, unable to hide our inner excitement (laughs). As we walked, everyone was already taking tonnes of photos of the naval port scenery (laughs). I was fully prepared with both an SLR camera and a compact camera.

The vessel we were allowed to tour was the destroyer "Teshio." Among the Self-Defence Force's ships, it was a medium-sized vessel. We were shown the destroyer's deck, the command post on the bridge, corridors inside the ship, mess hall, officers' quarters, and so on.

As usual, we were covering with the theatrical scenes in mind. Since the performances would be inside the ship with low ceilings and many watertight bulkheads, we used assistant director Hiroshima-san as a model and carefully photographed size comparisons with ceilings, walls, chairs, and tables.

French Navy vessels referenced by Japan Maritime Self-Defence Force vessels - well, the basics of warships probably aren't that different, right? (laughs)

Since it was docked, naturally the gun barrels were properly plugged with stoppers, and the missile pods were empty. While it's a warship of exclusive defence that basically doesn't engage in combat, there was still a kind of cold tension emanating from the bridge instruments and even the deck hatches and handrails. Ah, this is the kind of thing you only get from seeing the real thing.

When you see the real thing, there are various combat ship-specific innovations in all sorts of places - it was incredibly educational. For example, even something like a mess

hall table was designed so dishes wouldn't fall off during ocean swells. The hatch opening and closing mechanisms - actually touching them, operating them, each thing was moving.

Before I knew it, I had used up all six rolls of 36-exposure film I'd brought (laughs).

At the end, perhaps as "service," they spun the latest anti-aircraft gun around at high speed for us! Everyone was excited!

And that was the end of COO's location scouting. Now we would finally enter the main production work.

(09.02.18)